

Blog: When the Cat's Away...

"When the cat's away the mice will play" is a rhyming proverb. It can also be described as a metaphor wherein the cat is a metaphor for a person in charge, and the mouse is a metaphor for someone who has to obey the person in charge.

When you apply this metaphor you create a cause-and-effect relationship between the cat and the mouse: if one does this, the other does that. I like metaphors most when they incorporate witty wordplay with rhyme. This style can easily teach a dynamic life lesson using just a few words. Speakers and teachers who know how to use such metaphorical rhyming proverbs have power within their speaking. They will use the wisdom of a metaphor to affirm decisions and gain popular support. And with the addition of good timing, a rhyming proverb can provide emphasis to subtle truths, and achieve great depths of understanding to otherwise ethereal concepts.

I saw this particular proverb play out as a young fellow approached a red light on an electric bike last week. He was in the far-right lane of a very busy street. His feet were dangling from the bike, rolling along dismissively at 25 mph, while seeming to ignore the inherent dangers of being on a thoroughfare riding a 30-pound vehicle alongside several 2,000-pound machines in motion. I was fascinated at his cavalier nature, right up to the time he recognized that a motorcycle police officer had pulled up to his left at the same red-light intersection.

I was stopped at the same light, in the right-turn lane next to him, and chuckled to myself as I watched the young man look down at his front tire. He then looked at the police officer and casually rolled his electric bike backward about eight inches, in order not to cross the limit line to retreat from being in the intersection.

Now, it could be that this young fellow's physical view of the limit line was previously obstructed. Or, it is plausible that the young man did not know what that line at the crosswalk meant. But with the Police Officer only eight feet away, the value of his awareness and the legal consequence of crossing that limit line was recalled from deep in his conscience. I sensed clearly that his behavior was modified by the presence of authority flanking him to his left.

I saw this proverb play out similarly with residents we inherited when we purchased a 20-unit apartment property. As we did our due diligence on the property last December, we found that of the 20 units, one unit was vacant and the other 19 units were fully occupied. However, only seven of those 19 residents were current on their rent. Two of the nonpaying tenants had not paid rent in a year, which is plenty of time for a property owner to improperly train a tenant to disregard any notices for demand of payment. And by the way, there was one tenant who awarded himself the personal right to decide what was, and what wasn't, acceptable levels of noise and mischief for other residents on the property. He awarded himself the freedom to make that determination.

We found that the tenants who were not paying rent were provided no accountability, no threat of consequences, and no follow-up by management. The tenants were effectively trained to disrespect the property, disrespect management, and disrespect one another while encouraging further disrepair. This sense of defiance will always spiral once residents realize that the landlord does not value the property or respect their right to a clean and livable condition. But it doesn't stop there. The attitude of

avoidance by the previous owner attracted like-minded residents looking to live in a place where responsibility and cleanliness is held hostage to recreation.

Today, nearly 10 months later, we have taken this property from a disastrous tenant profile to responsible residents who have had their living conditions raised to a standard that will contribute to making their children's futures brighter. The building is in the process of being repainted and the security system repaired. Over half of the units have had their interiors fully renovated, with the other nine units scheduled to be completed by the 12th month of our ownership. The aggregation of trash and broken furniture dispersed throughout the property has been removed, and drought-tolerant landscaping has replaced former patches of dirt through weekly scheduled lawncare. This property, known as *Kenwood Manor*, is now back on track to be fully renovated and stabilized *on time* and *in budget*.

Once the project is fully completed, the optics will provide an amazing contrast. The residents already know that **the "Cat"** is in town and has established clear boundaries. The result is a new sense of safety, cleanliness, and community.

The impact of this proverb has played out often in VisionWise Capital's history. We play the role of **the "Cat"**. But we only chase out **the "Mice"** who cannot, or will not, learn to play well together.

*We manage by measuring the difference we can make in people's **lives**.*

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